

The Indian National Congress (1885–1947)

Every session, every president, every "first" — from A.O. Hume's founding to J.B. Kripalani at Independence

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Why this chapter matters: INC session-and-president questions are pure memorisation — but they're asked almost every single SSC cycle, in "match the session with the year/president/resolution" format. This chapter organises every session chronologically so you can build one mental timeline instead of memorising isolated facts.

1 Founding of the Indian National Congress

Fact	Answer
Founder	Allan Octavian Hume (A.O. Hume), a Scotsman
Founded	1885, Bombay (first session)
Formally named "Indian National Congress"	1886, in Calcutta — the naming is credited to Dadabhai Naoroji
First General Secretary	A.O. Hume himself (same person as founder)
Viceroy of India at founding	Lord Dufferin (1884–1888)
British Prime Minister at founding (1885)	William Gladstone

Don't confuse these Prime Ministers: **Palmerston** was PM during the **1857 Revolt**; **Clement Attlee** was PM at **Independence (1947)**; **Gladstone** was PM when the **INC was founded (1885)**. Lord Minto was never PM — he was only ever a Viceroy.

PYQ: Who is credited with naming the party the "Indian National Congress"? **Ans: Dadabhai Naoroji**

2 The First Session (1885, Bombay)

- Presided over by **Womesh Chandra Bonnerjee**.
- The **proposal** to hold the session was originally made by **G. Subramania Iyer**, initially intended for Pune — the Pune plan failed and the venue shifted to Bombay.

3 Second Session (1886, Calcutta)

Presided by **Dadabhai Naoroji** (called the "**Grand Old Man of India**"). The **Indian Association** (founded by Surendranath Banerjee) merged into the INC during this session.

4 Sessions With Notable "Firsts"

Session (Year)	President	"First" achieved
Madras, 1887	Badruddin Tyabji	First Muslim president
Allahabad, 1888	George Yule	First English/British (non-Indian) president; also the first elected European president
Calcutta, 1917	Annie Besant	First woman president (of any nationality)
1925 (Kanpur)	Sarojini Naidu	First Indian-born woman president
Delhi (special), 1923	Maulana Abul Kalam Azad	Youngest-ever president
Faizpur, 1936	Jawaharlal Nehru	First session held in a village

5 Key Sessions Timeline (1896–1920) 🔥

Year / Place	President	Key event
1896, Calcutta	—	Vande Mataram (from Bankim Chandra's novel <i>Anandmath</i>) sung publicly for the first time
1905, Banaras	Gopal Krishna Gokhale	—
1906, Calcutta	Dadabhai Naoroji	Word " Swaraj " used for the first time; demand for free primary education ; four resolutions passed — Swadeshi, Boycott, National Education, Swarajya (self-government)
1907, Surat	—	INC splits into Moderates ("Naram") and Extremists ("Garam") — the "Surat Split"
1909, Lahore	Madan Mohan Malaviya	(Malaviya later founded the Hindu Mahasabha in 1915)
1911, Calcutta	—	National anthem " Jana Gana Mana " sung for the first time
1916, Lucknow	Ambika Charan Majumdar	Tilak declares " Swaraj is my birthright, and I shall have it "; Moderate-Extremist reunification; the Lucknow Pact between INC and the Muslim League
1920 (special), Calcutta	—	Non-Cooperation Movement resolution passed

"Ambassador of Hindu-Muslim Unity": A title given to **Muhammad Ali Jinnah** by **Sarojini Naidu** — worth remembering given how differently Jinnah is remembered today.

Two different uses of "Swaraj" — don't confuse them: First used at the **1906 Calcutta session** by **Dadabhai Naoroji** (in the sense of self-government within the empire); later, in **1921**, **Hasrat Mohani** used the term with a more radical, complete-independence connotation — a distinction that has come up repeatedly in UP-state exams.

PYQ: In which session did Bal Gangadhar Tilak declare "Swaraj is my birthright"? **Ans: Lucknow session, 1916**

6 The Lal-Bal-Pal Trio — Only One Became President

Of the famous trio **Lala Lajpat Rai**, **Bal Gangadhar Tilak**, and **Bipin Chandra Pal** — only **Lala Lajpat Rai** ever became INC president. Tilak and Bipin Chandra Pal both had ongoing British court cases against them at various points, which kept them from the post; Lala Lajpat Rai, by contrast, had a "clean/white-collar" public image and was also an industrialist.

7 Sessions From 1924 to 1931 🔥

Session (Year)	President	Significance
Belgaum, 1924	Mahatma Gandhi	The only INC session ever presided over by Gandhi
Lahore, 1929	Jawaharlal Nehru	Purna Swaraj (complete independence) resolution passed on the banks of the Ravi river ; Vice-President: Subhas Chandra Bose
Karachi, 1931	Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel	Resolution demanding Fundamental Rights ; Gandhi's statement " You can kill Gandhi, but you cannot kill Gandhism " was also made here

8 Faizpur, Haripura & Tripuri (1936–1939)

- **Faizpur, 1936** — the **first (and only) session held in a village**, in Maharashtra.
- **Haripura, 1938** and **Tripuri, 1939** — both presided over by **Subhas Chandra Bose**.

The "Tripuri Crisis": Bose could not complete his term as president due to internal party conflict and ill health, and resigned. **Rajendra Prasad** was chosen to succeed him as INC's leader.

9 Youngest & Longest-Serving President

Maulana Abul Kalam Azad holds **two** records: he became the **youngest-ever INC president** at the **1923 special Delhi session**, and he also served as the **longest-serving president** — a continuous **6-year term**, from **1940 to 1946**.

10 Quit India to Independence (1942–1947)

Year	Event
1942	The "Quit India" resolution, at the Bombay session , was moved/presented by Jawaharlal Nehru
1947	INC president at the moment of Independence: J.B. Kripalani — also remembered as free India's first INC president

11 After Independence — Should Congress Be Disbanded?

Soon after Independence, **Mahatma Gandhi** suggested that the Congress party had fulfilled its purpose and should be **disbanded** — a suggestion that, notably, was never acted upon.

The first INC session held after Independence took place at **Jaipur**, presided over by **Pattabhi Sitaramayya** (author of the book *The History of the Congress*). This session also saw the formation of the **JVP Committee** — **Jawaharlal Nehru**, **Vallabhbhai Patel**, and **Pattabhi Sitaramayya**.

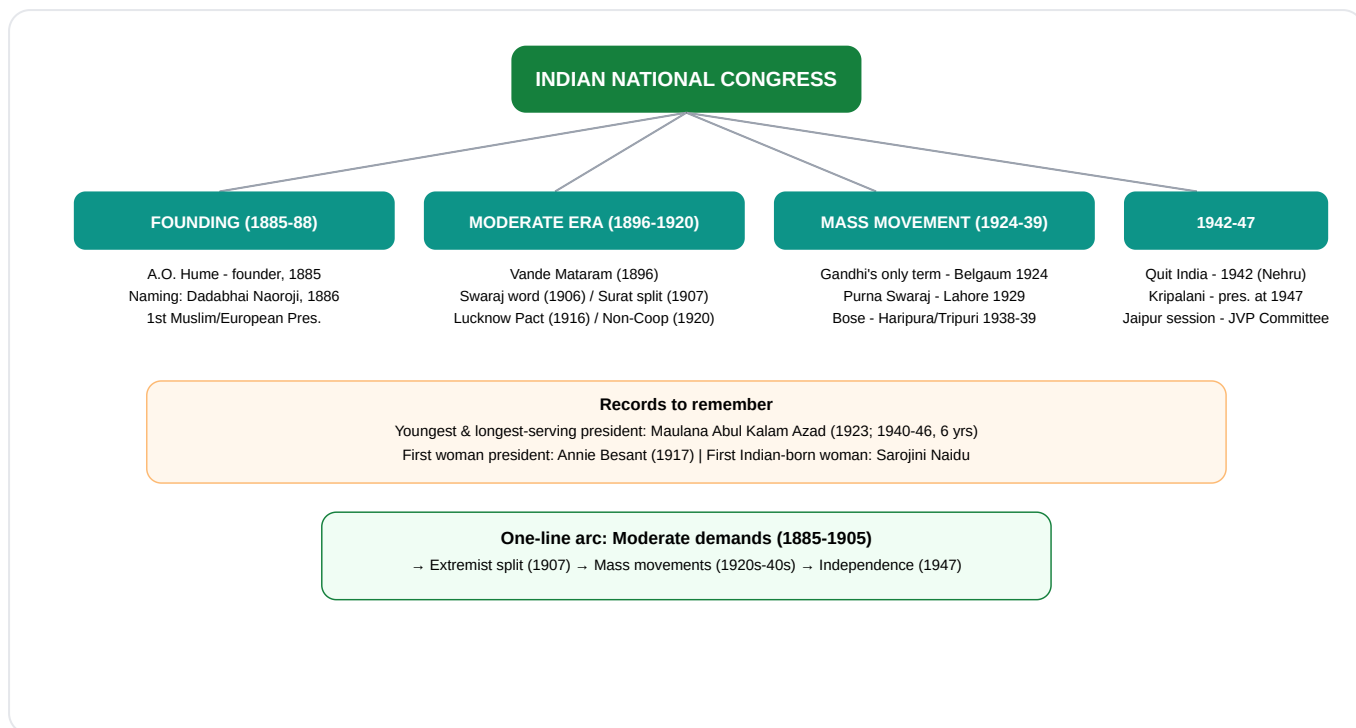
Homework question from the lecture: Who mocked the INC as representing only a **"microscopic minority"** of the Indian people? The well-established historical answer is Viceroy **Lord Dufferin** (in a speech around 1887–88) — worth confirming against your specific exam's answer key.

12 Master Reference Table — All Sessions at a Glance

Year	Place	President	Key point
1885	Bombay	W.C. Bonnerjee	First session
1886	Calcutta	Dadabhai Naoroji	Naming of INC; Indian Association merges in
1887	Madras	Badruddin Tyabji	First Muslim president
1888	Allahabad	George Yule	First English/European president
1896	Calcutta	—	Vande Mataram first sung
1905	Banaras	G.K. Gokhale	—
1906	Calcutta	Dadabhai Naoroji	"Swaraj" first used; 4 resolutions
1907	Surat	—	Naram-Garam split
1909	Lahore	Madan Mohan Malaviya	—
1911	Calcutta	—	Jana Gana Mana first sung
1916	Lucknow	Ambika Charan Majumdar	Tilak's "birthright" speech; Lucknow Pact
1917	Calcutta	Annie Besant	First woman president
1920 (special)	Calcutta	—	Non-Cooperation resolution
1923 (special)	Delhi	Abul Kalam Azad	Youngest president
1924	Belgaum	Mahatma Gandhi	Gandhi's only session as president
1929	Lahore	Jawaharlal Nehru	Purna Swaraj resolution
1931	Karachi	Sardar Patel	Fundamental Rights resolution
1936	Faizpur	Jawaharlal Nehru	First village session

Year	Place	President	Key point
1938	Haripura	Subhas Chandra Bose	—
1939	Tripuri	Subhas Chandra Bose	Tripuri crisis; succeeded by Rajendra Prasad
1942	Bombay	—	Quit India resolution (moved by Nehru)
1947 (Independence)	—	J.B. Kripalani	President at Independence
Post-Independence	Jaipur	Pattabhi Sitaramayya	First post-Independence session; JVP Committee formed

13 Mind Map — Indian National Congress



14 30-Second Revision

Fact	Value
Founder / year	A.O. Hume / 1885
Named by	Dadabhai Naoroji, 1886
First Muslim / European president	Badruddin Tyabji / George Yule
First woman president	Annie Besant, 1917
Swaraj word first used	1906 Calcutta, by Dadabhai Naoroji
Naram-Garam split	1907, Surat
Gandhi's only session as president	1924, Belgaum
Purna Swaraj resolution	1929, Lahore
Youngest / longest-serving president	Abul Kalam Azad (both)
President at Independence	J.B. Kripalani

15 PYQs from the Video (with Answers)

1. Who founded the Indian National Congress?

Ans: A.O. Hume

2. Who named the Indian National Congress in 1886?

Ans: Dadabhai Naoroji

3. Who was the General Secretary of the INC at its founding?

Ans: A.O. Hume

4. Who presided over the first INC session?

Ans: Womesh Chandra Bonnerjee

5. Who proposed the resolution to hold the first INC session?

Ans: G. Subramania Iyer

6. Who was Britain's Prime Minister at the time of INC's founding (1885)?

Ans: William Gladstone

7. Who presided over the second INC session (Calcutta, 1886)?

Ans: Dadabhai Naoroji

8. In which session did the Indian Association merge into the INC?

Ans: The 1886 Calcutta session

9. Who was the INC's first Muslim president?

Ans: Badruddin Tyabji (1887, Madras)

10. Who was INC's first English/non-Indian president?

Ans: George Yule (1888, Allahabad)

11. Who was INC's first elected European president?

Ans: George Yule

12. In which session was "Vande Mataram" sung for the first time?

Ans: 1896, Calcutta session

13. Who presided over the 1905 Banaras session?

Ans: Gopal Krishna Gokhale

14. In which session was "Swaraj" used for the first time?

Ans: 1906, Calcutta session, by Dadabhai Naoroji

15. Who used the word "Swaraj" in 1921?

Ans: Hasrat Mohani

16. In which session was free primary education first demanded?

Ans: 1906, Calcutta session

17. Which four resolutions were passed at the 1906 Calcutta session?

Ans: Swadeshi, Boycott, National Education, and Swarajya (self-government)

18. When did the INC split into Moderates and Extremists?

Ans: 1907, Surat session

19. Who presided over the 1909 Lahore session?

Ans: Madan Mohan Malaviya

20. When and where was the national anthem "Jana Gana Mana" first sung?

Ans: 1911, Calcutta

21. In which session did Tilak say "Swaraj is my birthright and I shall have it"?

Ans: Lucknow session, 1916

22. Who presided over the 1916 Lucknow session?

Ans: Ambika Charan Majumdar

23. Who was called the "Ambassador of Hindu-Muslim Unity", and by whom?

Ans: Jinnah; by Sarojini Naidu

24. Who was the INC's first woman president?

Ans: Annie Besant, 1917

25. In which session was the Non-Cooperation Movement resolution passed?

Ans: 1920 special session, Calcutta

26. Which member of the Lal-Bal-Pal trio became INC president?

Ans: Lala Lajpat Rai

27. Which was the only INC session presided over by Mahatma Gandhi?

Ans: Belgaum, 1924

28. Who was the INC's first (Indian-born) woman president?

Ans: Sarojini Naidu

29. In which session was Purna Swaraj demanded?

Ans: Lahore session, 1929

30. Who was Vice-President at the 1929 Lahore session?

Ans: Subhas Chandra Bose

31. In which session were Fundamental Rights demanded?

Ans: Karachi session, 1931

32. Who presided over the 1931 Karachi session?

Ans: Sardar Patel

33. Where was Gandhi's statement "You can kill Gandhi, but not Gandhism" made?

Ans: Karachi session, 1931

34. Which INC session was held in a village?

Ans: Faizpur, 1936

35. Who presided over the Haripura session?

Ans: Subhas Chandra Bose

36. When was the Tripuri session held, and who presided?

Ans: 1939; Subhas Chandra Bose (though he could not complete his term)

37. Who was chosen as INC leader after Bose's resignation?

Ans: Rajendra Prasad

38. Who was the youngest-ever INC president?

Ans: Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, 1923 (special Delhi session)

39. Who served the longest continuous term as INC president?

Ans: Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, 1940–1946 (6 years)

40. Who moved the Quit India resolution in 1942 at the Bombay session?

Ans: Jawaharlal Nehru

41. Who was INC president when India became independent?

Ans: J.B. Kripalani

42. Who suggested, after Independence, that the Congress party be disbanded?

Ans: Mahatma Gandhi

43. Where was the first post-Independence INC session held, and who presided?

Ans: Jaipur; Pattabhi Sitaramayya

44. What committee was formed at the Jaipur session, and who were its members?

Ans: The JVP Committee — Jawaharlal Nehru, Vallabhbhai Patel, Pattabhi Sitaramayya

45. Which book did Pattabhi Sitaramayya write?

Ans: The History of the Congress

16 Extra Practice (Beyond the Video)

E1. Who criticised the INC as representing a "microscopic minority" of Indians?

Ans: Viceroy Lord Dufferin (c. 1887–88)

E2. What was the INC originally called before adopting its final name in 1886?

Ans: The Indian National Union

E3. How many delegates attended the first INC session in 1885?

Ans: 72 delegates

E4. Which session saw the Congress-Khilafat-Swarajya alliance's council-entry proposal defeated, contributing to the Swaraj Party's formation?

Ans: The Gaya session, 1922

E5. Who founded the Swaraj Party in 1923, after the failure of the council-entry proposal?

Ans: C.R. Das and Motilal Nehru

17 Bonus — Standard-Syllabus Points (Not in the Video)

Commonly tested alongside "Indian National Congress" but not explicitly covered in the lecture. Verified against standard references.

- **1907 Surat Split — deeper cause:** The immediate trigger was a dispute over the choice of session president (Lal Lajpat Rai vs Rash Behari Ghosh) and deeper ideological differences between Moderates and Extremists on the pace and methods of the freedom struggle.
- **1929 Lahore Session — the flag and the pledge:** The tricolour flag was hoisted on the banks of the Ravi at midnight on 31 December 1929, and 26 January 1930 was declared "Purna Swaraj Day" / Independence Day (observed until 1947, then repurposed as Republic Day from 1950).
- **Gaya Session, 1922:** Presided by C.R. Das; the council-entry proposal (to contest provincial council elections) was defeated here, directly leading to the formation of the Swaraj Party in 1923 by C.R. Das and Motilal Nehru.
- **Avadi Session, 1955:** A post-Independence landmark session (Jawaharlal Nehru presiding) that adopted the goal of a "socialistic pattern of society" as state policy — useful if your syllabus extends into post-1947 Congress history.

Cross-check all dates with your NCERT Class VIII "Our Past III" and Class XII "Themes in Indian History-III" for the standard textbook framing.
This is **Part 5 of an 8-part series** covering the full lecture. The Revolt of 1857 is covered next in **Part 6**.